Paradoxes, Tensions and Challenges in Decentering the Human

Rosan W. Chow
OTH Regensburg
Faculty of Architecture
Regensburg, Germany
rosan.chow@oth-regensburg.de

Judith Dörrenbächer
University of Siegen
Ubiquitous Design / Experience & Interaction
Siegen, Germany
judith.doerrenbaecher@uni-siegen.de

Anton Poikolainen Rosén
Stockholm University
Department of Computer and Systems Sciences
Stockholm, Sweden
anton.poikolainenrosen@dsv.su.se

Daisy Yoo
Eindhoven University of Technology
Industrial Design
Eindhoven, Netherlands
d.yoo@tue.nl

Eva Eriksson
Aarhus University
Aarhus, Denmark
evae@cc.au.dk

Marc Hassenzahl
University of Siegen
Ubiquitous Design / Experience & Interaction
Siegen, Germany
marc.hassenzahl@uni-siegen.de

Abstract

In recent years, More-Than-Human-Design (MTHD) has gained traction in HCI, as exemplified by a growing body of workshops and publications. As this nascent field progresses, unresolved conceptual and practical methodological challenges continue to surface. It is time for MTHD researchers to critically revisit underlying assumptions, concepts and processes that shape their work. We invite the DIS community to engage with two central themes: first, a critical exploration of anthropocentrism - a core yet complex issue in MTHD; and second, the presentation of practical work that either highlights tensions within MTHD (e.g. how to decenter the human), or proposes ways to navigate these tensions constructively. Through mapping and discussing the challenges, we aim to identify patterns and shared concerns. The workshop will culminate in an open-ended Archive of Tensions, accessible via the workshop website, serving as a collective resource for ongoing reflection and inquiry. Furthermore, the Archive will be presented in an online event and the results will be published as an article.

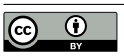
CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing → HCI theory, concepts and models**.

Keywords

More-Than-Human, Anthropocentrism, Paradoxes, Decenter human

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1 Background

In recent years, More-Than-Human-Design (MTHD) has gained traction in HCI, as exemplified by a growing body of workshops and publications [2, 7, 8, 12, 15, 18]. This year's DIS conference further reflects this development by explicitly calling to move beyond the human-centered perspective. As this nascent field progresses, unresolved conceptual and practical methodological challenges continue to emerge, including open questions [13], paradoxes [4], ambivalences [17], and tensions [9], to name just a few. Adding to these challenges, the key concept of anthropocentrism remains multifaceted, and at times conflated despite earnest efforts to clarify it, as attempted by Nicenboim et al. [13]. Moreover, while MTHD continues to evolve and new methods emerge, key questions concerning how to decenter humans and how to engage with more-than-human actors remain open for deeper and further investigation [5, 15]. To this end, we seek thought-provoking ideas, research and best practices that,

(1) revisit the key concept anthropocentrism,
(2) explore the paradoxes in the process of decentering human and engaging with the non-human.

2 WORKSHOP THEMES

2.1 Theoretical Tensions: Revisit the Key Concept Anthropocentrism

Researchers of MTHD are diverse in terms of the theories and methods they employ, issues that motivate them and the domains in which and technology with which they practice [5]. Despite this diversity, they share a common commitment, namely a critical stance towards anthropocentrism. In brief, anthropocentrism is criticized for its narcissistic notion of human being exceptional – above, different and separate from the rest of the world; and its egoistic tendency to privilege oneself above all else. The anti-human-exceptionalism-egoism ethos is the pivotal critique driving MTHD and the call to decenter human is understandable and laudable. However, besides being a position of value, anthropocentrism might also be understood as a condition that we cannot escape. Krippendorff [10], a design theorist, a communication scholar and a

cybernetician, is a strong defender of such a view when proposing Human-Centered-Design (HCD). Although not unknown to the HCI communities, his theory of HCD does not figure much in the MTHD discourse. Drawing on multiple strands of scholarship, he argues that knowing is a result of embodied human acting, making and languaging. He emphasizes the human involvement in knowledge construction by claiming, "The outside world is not knowable as such except through sensing the consequences of one's own action" [10, p. 59]. He insists that humans are bound to their own bodies when seeing, experiencing, interacting with, and creating meanings of the world. In this sense, de-centering the human is not possible (when designing). Being sympathetic towards the efforts made by the MTHD communities, we are not defending the type of human-centered perspective that is insufficient for designing networked and autonomous technologies [3, 6], that is focused on short-term needs and consumption habits [7], or that is modelling the user on the white male able-bodied [12]. We do want to differentiate between the value position of a "narcissistic-egoistic anthropocentrism" and the condition of an "embodied anthropocentrism"; as arguably, the differentiation might carry implications for resolving some methodological challenges in MTHD. For example, the notion of "embodied anthropocentrism" ironically fits well with the posthumanist theories on which MTHD is based. The critical stance toward the "narcissistic-egoistic anthropocentrism" has three major concerns, namely 1. material agency, 2. situated and multiple knowledges, and 3. an emphasis on relations and processes [11]. What is seldom made explicit in the MTHD discourse is the human's involvement in 1, the multiplicity of humans is the prerequisite of 2, and 3 is a different way to think about human. It seems that not only "embodied anthropocentrism" is inescapable, but it is also essential to MTHD practices. We therefore invite the MTHD communities to revisit the central concept anthropocentrism by examining, for example, the following questions:

- Is MTH a corrective or extension of Humanist tenets, rather than their antithesis?
  - Is the critical stance toward human exceptionalism/egoism more about human than the non-human?
  - Is assigning agency, rights and justice to the non-human or recognizing multiple intelligences and knowledges not a striving to be better humans?
- If "embodied anthropocentrism" is inescapable and a good fit to posthumanist theories,
  - how might the notion and the goal of decentering human be delimited, qualified or clarified?
  - which helpful concepts might be introduced to guide the discourse?
  - how to avoid unintentional self-deception/blind spots?

2.2 Practical Tensions: Explore the Paradoxes in the Process of Decentering Human and Engaging with the Non-Human

For many MTHD researchers, the greatest paradox and tension of their works is to practice posthumanist design while apparently being a human designer The tension arises, for example, from:

- Being self-centered to decenter the self: Biggs et al. describe the uncomfortable feelings of alienation when decentering – decentering involves fears of losing the self [1]. Rolighed et al. [14] who design a tool enabling humans to listen to a plant, point out that while it is possible to design products with non-human interests in mind, design decisions are still made by and for humans: "it is the human user who senses, analyzes, and reflects on the signals conveyed by the plant". Echoing others, Sheikh et al. argue that the reasons for designing for plants are human's interests in harvesting and selling wood from the forest. In a similar vein, Wakkary et al. [17] express having mixed feelings or contradictory ideas about the choices they made during their more-than-human design process, such as ambivalences and open questions of how to intervene in multispecies worlds without controlling these worlds.
- Adopting a non-human perspective as a human: Nicenboim et al. [13] point out the challenge of adopting the non-human perspectives and in the meantime coping with the impossibility of accessing non-human perspectives. In the same token, Key et al. [9] describe the tension of representing non-humans without humanizing them. For example, by using human categories and language in representing non-human, the non-human is framed as in need of "our" help.
- Using fixed entities to think relationally: Eriksson et al. [5] highlight the challenging complexity that arises when designers think in assemblages of humans and non-humans. Key et al. [9] concur that thinking about entities relationally, constituted with and through others is far more difficult than thinking in terms of clean-cut categories.

The various critical reflections of designers on their own MTHD practice echo the theoretical discussion in section 2.1. In this workshop, we aim to build on and further explore these practical challenges by investigating the following subjects:

- Many MTHD researchers have genuine concerns about the more-than-human world: how to care for the non-human which might be indifferent to human care?
- Technological artefacts are developed to preserve non-humans and ecosystems: how to avoid dangerous dependencies due to solutionism?
- Humans are material-discursive and physical-social beings: how to engage with non-humans without imposing our languages and discourses? How to make sense of non-humans without anthropomorphizing them?
- Many MTHD methods rely heavily on bodily, sensorial, and explorative forms of knowing: are these methods – that are bound to the human body – contradictory to the more-than-human perspectives? Or/and are they the key to resolve the tensions?
- Humans tend to form categories when thinking: how to handle 'entanglement', 'relational ontology' and complexity in general without falling back to categorization? Is it possible?

3 ANTICIPATED OUTCOMES

In this one-day workshop, we invite researchers to contribute theoretical reflections on the concept of anthropocentrism as well as insights into the tensions they encounter in their practical MTHD processes. Each submission will include initial thoughts on how

these tensions might be navigated. During the workshop, we will not only analyze and map the tensions but also explore ways to navigate and integrate them within MTHD. For instance: Could the challenge of adopting the non-human perspective as a human be addressed by altering the human body – by becoming a non-human? Might meditation help counteract the human tendency to take control, fostering instead a sense of "response-ability" that allows space for others to act? The resulting mapping will culminate in an open-ended Archive of Tensions, accessible via the workshop website[1]. We believe that one of the most important obligations of MTHD is to surface paradoxes, make them transparent, and invite open discussion on how to navigate them. The Archive of Tensions will serve as an initial collective resource for ongoing reflection and inquiry in MTHD. Further, the workshop results will be presented during an online event at the DESIGN+POSTHUMANISM NETWORK and we aim at a paper published in the forum "More-than-Human Design in Practice" of the Interactions Magazine. We are confident that the energy of the workshop can also be harnessed to collaboratively publish a special issue or an edited volume on the topic of how to navigate tensions in MTHD.

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